Week 1 Teacher Guide — The Purpose of the Good

The Obedience of Faith, Week 1 of 12. Companion to the deck `Week01-PurposeOfTheGood.pptx` *(8 slides, 30 click-stops). Scripture from the NET Bible.*

Aim: Establish that goodness is God's own character, its purpose is union with His people, and the course's controlling verse is Hebrews 5:14.

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): plant three sentences the class can repeat — *the Good has a source; its purpose is union; recognizing it is trained by practice.* Every later week hangs on those three. Resist covering sacrifice, testing, or church order this week; the road slide previews them and that is enough.

Segment 1 — "Why Do You Call Me Good?" (0:00–10:00 · Slide 2)

Open before the first click with ordinary speech: good coffee, a good dog, a good deal, a good man. Ask the room — no hands needed, just let it hang — *what standard does each of those silently borrow?* Good coffee borrows your palate. A good deal borrows the market. A good man borrows… what, exactly? That unfinished question is the lecture's doorway.

The text. A man runs up to Jesus with a compliment attached to a question: "Good teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?" And Jesus, before answering the question, interrogates the compliment: "Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone" (Mark 10:17–18).

The move to teach carefully: Jesus is not denying his goodness — the same Gospels present him as the sinless one. He is auditing the man's vocabulary. The man used "good" as a *measurement* — a grade he was qualified to award. Jesus treats it as an *identification* — a name that belongs to God. The unspoken question underneath: *do you realize what you just called me?*

The doctrinal payoff: goodness is not a free-floating quality that people or things possess independently. Anything called good is good because it *participates* in Him — borrows from His character the way moonlight borrows from the sun. (If your class enjoys the history: Augustine and the early writers said exactly this — created goods are good by participation in the Good himself. Use or skip; the text carries the point without it.)

The Old Testament witness (final click): when Moses asked to see God's glory, God answered, "I will make all my goodness pass before your face, and I will proclaim the LORD by name before you" (Exodus 33:19) — goodness and the Name travel together. And Psalm 34:8: "Taste and see that the LORD is good!" Goodness in Scripture is *met*, not merely measured.

Transition line: "If the Good is a Person, then the Good has a purpose — because persons have purposes. So what is goodness *for*?"

Segment 2 — The Purpose Is God's Purpose (10:00–20:00 · Slide 3)

The three-box arc builds on clicks: **Created in His image** (Gen 1:26–27) → **The image marred** (Gen 3) → **Conformed to His Son** (Rom 8:29).

- **Box 1.** "Let us make humankind in our image, after our likeness." Humanity was made to *resemble and relate* — image is both a likeness and an appointment. This is what the Good was for from the first page.
- **Box 2.** One sentence only — Genesis 3 defaced the likeness but did not erase it. Tell the class Week 6 returns here in depth (the serpent's method). Note the visual: this box renders *faded* on screen. Say so — "the image marred, not erased."
- **Box 3.** Romans 8:29 — "predestined to be conformed to the image of his Son, that his Son would be the firstborn among many brothers and sisters." The purpose never changed. Conformity to Christ is Genesis 1:26 kept, not replaced. And note the family word: *firstborn among many brothers and sisters.* The destination is not a standard met but a household joined.

The two summary clicks: the purpose of the Good is not an abstract ethical puzzle; it is God's own purpose — union with the people He made, remade in His likeness. Then the phrase to land and repeat all course long: **union, not admiration.** Ask it rhetorically: "Does God want your *approval* of goodness — or your *participation* in it?" Let no one answer; the course answers.

Transition: "But there's a problem, and it's the problem this entire course exists to solve. How would anyone *know*?"

Segment 3 — The Problem: Devotion Is Invisible (20:00–26:00 · Slide 4)

This is the hinge segment. The claim: a disposition cannot be seen — love for God, trust, devotion are invisible **not just to your neighbor, but to you.** Say the second phrase twice; the first is obvious, the second is the course.

Three witnesses, one breath each (they are previews — Saul returns in Weeks 2–3, Malachi in Week 9, the "Lord, Lord" builders in Week 8; tell the class so): - Saul: "I have done what the Lord said" — and apparently believed it (1 Sam 15:13). - The priests: "How have we offended you?" — and meant it (Mal 1:7). - "Lord, Lord…" — and heard "I never knew you" (Matt 7:21–23).

The point: sincerity is real — and unverifiable. Every one of those people passed their own inspection. Which is why God commands the audit: "Put yourselves to the test to see if you are in the faith; examine yourselves!" (2 Cor 13:5).

Close the segment on the course question and pause a full three seconds after reading it: *How does the invisible become visible — and how does a person learn to see it?*

Pastoral note: the aim here is honest unease, not dread. If you sense the room tightening, add one sentence: "The good news is that Scripture answers both halves of that question — that's the next eleven weeks."

Segment 4 — The Controlling Verse (26:00–32:00 · Slide 5)

Read Hebrews 5:12 and let "by this time" do its work: the writer is doing math on his readers — years in the faith against what they can digest. Invite, don't shame: "Run his math on yourself, privately."

Then the controlling verse, read twice, slower the second time: "But solid food is for the mature, whose perceptions are **trained by practice** to discern both good and evil" (Heb 5:14).

Unpack the three words — *trained by practice*: discernment is not downloaded at baptism and not absorbed from sermons. It is built like a tradesman's eye. Pick the trade your class actually contains — the carpenter who spots the crooked joint without a tape measure, the nurse who reads a patient at a glance, the mechanic who hears the engine's problem. Reps, daily, until perception knows things the mouth can't yet explain. That is the word Hebrews chose.

Close the loop (final click): notice *what* the mature discern — good and evil. The course title and the course thesis are the same sentence: maturity is the trained ability to recognize the Good — God's own character, Segment 1 — from everything that merely resembles it.

Segment 5 — The Road, and Grace First (32:00–42:00 · Slide 6)

Walk the five units briskly, one sentence per click — Foundations (vocabulary), Discernment (method), Testing (the covenant pattern and ours), God's House (authority and order), Commission (sent to teach). Do not preview details; curiosity is an asset.

Then slow down completely for the grace click. Romans 12:1 begins "by the mercies of God" — mercy comes before the altar, grammatically and theologically. Say it plainly: *this is a course about obedience, and it cannot be heard as a course about earning. Nothing in these twelve weeks generates standing with God; all of it responds to a sacrifice already completed.* Tell the class you will repeat "mercy first, altar second" at Weeks 4, 7, 9, and 12 on purpose — naming the repetition in advance makes it a landmark instead of a tic.

Segments 6–7 — Discussion and the Rhythm (42:00–55:00 · Slides 7–8)

(Note: the brief's 42–45 "reading rhythm" segment is delivered as the close after discussion — it lands better as a send-off than as a lecture item.)

Discussion facilitation (10 min):

Q1 — "When you say something is 'good,' what standard are you actually using?" Collect two or three answers without correcting — expect "what I like," "what works," "what's moral," "what helps people." Then observe aloud: *every answer borrowed a standard from somewhere.* That observation is the entire point; don't press further.

Q2 — "What would change, practically, this week, if goodness were a Person's character rather than a measurement?" Push toward concrete. If the room is quiet, seed it: would it change how you evaluate a sermon? a purchase? a friendship? an argument you're currently winning? Good answers will connect goodness to relationship rather than scorekeeping — affirm those.

Set the course ground rule (last click on slide 7): disagreement is welcome, and every claim goes back to the text. We answer like Bereans — eager, and examining. Establishing this in Week 1 is what makes Weeks 6 and 11 safe later.

The close (slide 8, ~2 min): Acts 17:11 — both halves named: *eager* (they wanted it true) and *examining* (they checked, daily). The course's standing discipline is deliberately light: one passage per week, read daily if possible. Give next week's reading **with its two guiding questions** — Genesis 22:1–19 (*what exactly does God ask for, and when does Abraham's faith become visible?*) and Hebrews 11:17–19 (*what did Abraham reason, and what did the test prove?*). The questions are what make the reading Berean instead of passive. One-sentence preview of Week 2 — Sacrifice Reveals the Good, the four layers. End on Psalm 34:8 as an invitation, not an assignment, and dismiss on time. Week 1 ending punctually teaches the class more about the next eleven weeks than anything you say.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"Is Jesus saying he isn't good, or isn't God?" Neither. The saying is a test of the man's own words — either Jesus is good *and therefore* what the man said reaches further than he knew, or the compliment was empty flattery. Jesus never accepts flattery and never denies deity; he makes the man choose what he meant. The rich man's response (walking away from the call to follow, 10:21–22) shows which it was.

"Doesn't Genesis 1:31 call creation 'very good' — so goodness isn't

only God?" Right — and that is the participation point, not a counterexample. Creation is very good as *His* work, reflecting His character; the verse grades the craftsmanship by the Craftsman. Nothing in Genesis 1 is good independently of Him — which is exactly the claim.

"If devotion is invisible even to me, how can I ever have assurance?" Flag this as precisely where the course is going: Scripture's answer is that God provides *visible* forms — sacrifice, tests, fruit — so that faith is not left to introspection (1 John's "by this we know," Week 8). For now: 2 Cor 13:5 commands the examination, which means God intends it to be answerable. Don't resolve it fully in Week 1; a live question is fuel.

"Are you saying non-Christians can't do good things?" No — and head this off before it's asked if your class leans apologetic. Unbelievers do real good (Matt 7:11 — "you who are evil know how to give good gifts"). The claim is about the *source and standard* of goodness, not a denial of common grace. Every good thing anyone does borrows from His character; the question of the course is knowing and being united to the Owner.

Prep Checklist

- ☐ Read Mark 10:17–31 whole (the rich man's exit is your answer to the first likely question)
- ☐ Choose the tradesman illustration to fit *your* class roster
- ☐ Decide your Q2 seed examples in advance (sermon / purchase / friendship)
- ☐ Rehearse slide 3's five clicks and slide 6's six — the two multi-click sequences
- ☐ Print or post next week's reading with its two guiding questions
- ☐ Time check marks: slide 4 by 20:00, slide 6 by 32:00, discussion opens by 45:00
- ☐ If projecting: confirm animations run On Click (open Animation Pane once before class)

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: the Exodus 33 / Psalm 34 click on slide 2 (one sentence instead), then compress slide 6's unit walk to a single gesture at the screen. **Never cut:** the "even to you" phrase on slide 4, the double reading of Hebrews 5:14, or the mercy-first click on slide 6.